

Suspension

A suspension is a musical device for creating and resolving tension. A note is suspended from one chord over the next to create a temporary dissonance, which is then resolved when the suspended note falls to make the chord consonant.

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How do you make a suspension?

The music examples below show two imperfect cadences in F major. They both move from an F chord (I, or tonic) to a C chord (V, the dominant of F major). But in the second example, the fourth of the C chord, F, is suspended over the C and G, creating a 4:3 suspension, until it moves down to the E, which is the third of the chord.

- 126 ▽ **Character of a suspension**
Suspensions occur on strong beats and resolutions on weak beats. Here the strong beat is the first beat of the measure. The suspended note tends to fall, not rise, to its consonant resolution.

The cadence is identical, but the F is suspended over C and G.

Chord symbols indicate the movement from tonic (I) to dominant (V).

Doubling the C on an octave strengthens the "unfinished business" of the interrupted cadence.

REAL WORLD

Crucifixus

Many composers of choral music, old or new, use suspension to portray in music the "Crucifixus" text, which describes Jesus hanging on the cross. Italian Baroque composer Antonio Lotti wrote a particularly painful example, which uses suspended dissonance across eight separate vocal lines.



"A cluster of notes which opened the door to modern music." Stephen Fry on the Tristan chord